INTERNAL STRIFE

↘ Punjab BJP chief Sunil Jakhar is skipping key meetings ahead of panchayat polls, sparking resignation rumours and talk of an organisational reshuffle

↘ The former Congressman's appointment has backfired as he failed to deliver rural votes in the Lok Sabha election and there is resentment among the BJP old guard

highway" approach, out of sync with the collective ethos suitable for a cadre- and ideology-based party. Local Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh leaders feel he is often antagonistic and never consults them on key issues. Consequently, whispers of a major organisational reshuffle are growing louder, with the old guard pushing for an "energetic and committed" leader.

On his part, Jakhar feels sidelined, claiming he's not taken into confidence on crucial issues relating to Punjab—from dealing with farmer unions to selecting Lok Sabha candidates and engineering defections. Rubbing salt on the wound, Jakhar is reportedly miffed with the recent appointment of Ravneet Singh Bittu to the Union cabinet, despite his loss in the Lok Sabha election from Ludhiana. Bittu was also granted a Rajya Sabha seat from Rajasthan, a move that left Jakhar feeling overlooked and undervalued, admits a close associate.

In the past month, Jakhar has reportedly met Prime Minister Narendra Modi, home minister Amit Shah and BJP's national chief J.P. Nadda in New Delhi, sharing his mind with these top leaders. While reports from Chandigarh hint at Jakhar offering to resign, BJP leaders at both state and central levels have denied these claims even as he is turning into an enigma for them. Lest they forget, he had put the Congress high command in a similar spot before quitting the party in 2022. ■





MADHYA PRADESH

LIGHTS, CAMERA, ACTION

By Rahul Noronha

The craggy ravines have never disappointed Bollywood. The Sunil Dutt starrer *Mujhe Jeene Do* (1963), *Putli Bai* (1972), *Dacait* (1987), with Sunny Deol in the lead, *Bandit Queen* (1994) and *Paan Singh Tomar* (2012)—the dacoit genre had Madhya Pradesh as one of its most sought after filming destinations for six decades. Understandably so, for the legendary badlands of the Chambal, where numerous dacoit gangs were based, are located here. But in the past five years, the Hindi film industry has realised that there is much more to the state as a film shooting destination than a perfect setting for cops chasing dacoits on galloping horses. MP has now emerged as one of the most sought-after filming destinations for movies and OTT shows—as many as 400 movies and OTTs have been produced partly or wholly in the state in recent years.

Though all-time classics like *Shri 420* and *Naya Daur* were partly shot in MP way back in the 1950s, and even the offbeat *Teesri Kasam* was among the films that kept up the momentum in the '60s, the steady trickle of location scouts rarely looked beyond Indore, Bhopal and Gwalior till the 2010s. It was director Prakash Jha who in a sense re-